

KEY STRUCTURE

NUCLEAR SHELTER

Away from the cataclysmic centre of a nuclear explosion, people sheltering in deep underground bunkers would have a chance of survival. But the ensuing radioactive fallout would force survivors to remain underground for extended periods, requiring supplies of uncontaminated food, water, and recyclable air.



▲ This nuclear bunker was built in Moscow in 1956, anticipating the fear of an all-out nuclear conflict.

KEY EVENTS

1945–1955

- **6 August 1945** A US B-29 aircraft drops an atomic bomb on Hiroshima, marking a new era of nuclear warfare.
- **22 May 1947** President Harry S Truman commits the US to providing military assistance to any nation threatened by Communist aggression. This becomes known as the Truman Doctrine.
- **4 April 1949** The North Atlantic Treaty Organization (NATO) is formed, to provide a military bulwark against the Soviet Union.
- **1 November 1952** The US carries out the first successful test of a hydrogen bomb, on the Eniwetok atoll in the Pacific. The Soviet Union follows suit in 1953.
- **14 May 1955** The Warsaw Pact is agreed, a mutual defence treaty between the Soviet Union and the Communist states of eastern Europe.

► A US NUCLEAR TEST, NEVADA

US troops watch the mushroom cloud of an atomic explosion while on a field exercise in Nevada, in November 1951. They are just 9.5km (6 miles) from the explosion.

KEY DEVELOPMENT

THE COLD WAR ERA

The end of World War II witnessed the emergence of the Soviet Union and the US as global superpowers, and their ideological hostility was to define international politics for the remainder of the 20th century.

The enmity between these two superpowers was made especially dangerous by the advent of nuclear weapons. The US, the first of the two nations to develop an atomic bomb, used its nuclear supremacy to devastating effect against the Japanese cities of Hiroshima (see pp.378–79) and Nagasaki, in 1945; it lost its lead in 1949, however, when the Soviet Union developed its own atomic bomb. This marked the beginning of an arms race, as the two superpowers developed ever-more powerful weapons and more complex and accurate delivery

systems. Scientists invented the hydrogen bomb in the mid-1950s: the blast from the first hydrogen explosion was measured at 10.4 megatons, 450 times more powerful than the bomb dropped on Nagasaki.

Nuclear weapons were initially carried in bomber aircraft, but their vulnerability to air-defence systems soon became apparent. The solution was to supplement the use of bombers with ballistic missiles, which were difficult to intercept. They could be fired from concealed concrete silos and had the range to hit population

